

Ignorance is Easier to Heal

Audrina stares blankly at the table in front of them, a rarity for the overzealous person. They had volunteered for this. They had said it would be fun. Now they are here. Now they are making several individual care bags for tomorrow's cyborg protest and community event.

Meanwhile, Rama Babette Oxley carries a large box of shelf-stable snacks as if it were nothing. Short-term effort for a longer-term impact on those who need the help the community will provide. "Audrina," she calls, glancing at their face, "you good, pal?"

Audrina blinks, shakes their head, and sighs hard. "Yeah," they mumble.

"More than you expected." It isn't a question.

Audrina huffs.

"It's okay," Rama laughs, setting the box down and coming over to squeeze their shoulder gently. "This is just the demanding part you aren't used to. *Yet.*"

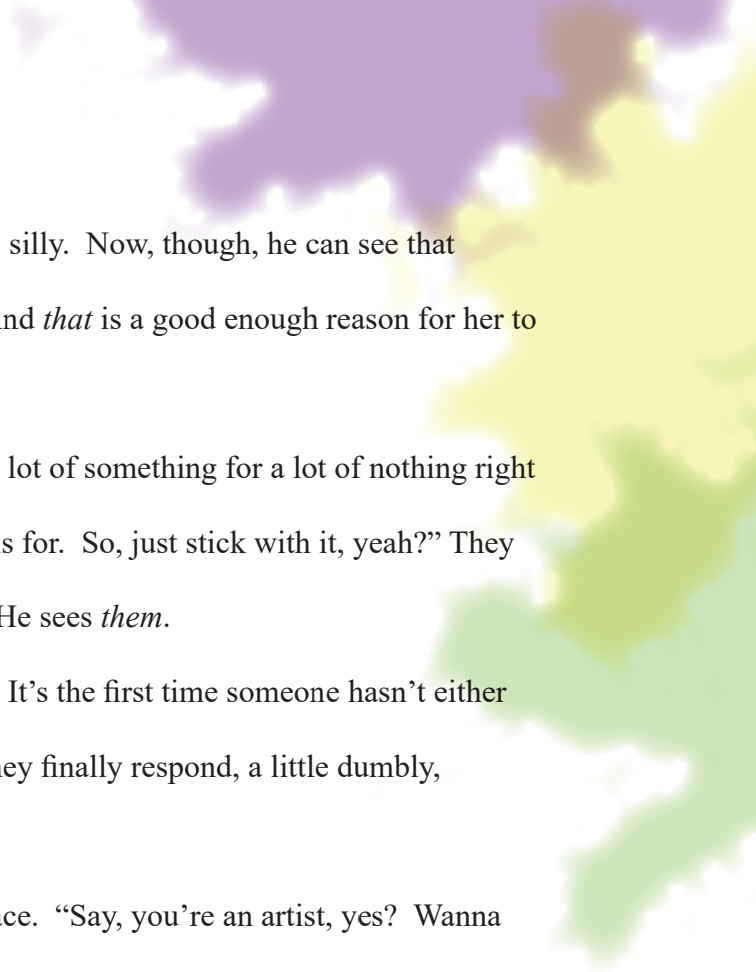
"Is it always like this?" They try so hard not to whine it. They are only half successful.

Rama grins. "No. Depends on the event. But it all takes work."

Audrina huffs and curls inwards, crossing their arms and pouting. The toddler is coming home, but Audrina knows better. This little act hasn't gotten them anywhere since their fathers stopped giving in. However, the occasional laugh out of Dice was worth it.

But the irritation refused to bleed out. Why weren't they allowed just to come in and yell and make friends like usual? Why are they here a day early? And how is Rama so content with this?

Rama watches them, their eyes thinning out and lips pressing together. She can practically smell the entitlement she clocked the first time they met. This wasn't an uncommon sight in activism. The performance is the reason to exist. The pictures and fun parts are the why.



A younger Rama found it annoying and, at best, silly. Now, though, he can see that Audrina is, even if unconsciously, willing to change. And *that* is a good enough reason for her to stay by their side.

“Friend, give it time. It feels like we’re doing a lot of something for a lot of nothing right now. But tomorrow, you’ll see what and *who* we do this for. So, just stick with it, yeah?” They tilt their head, giving Audrina a more empathic smile. He sees *them*.

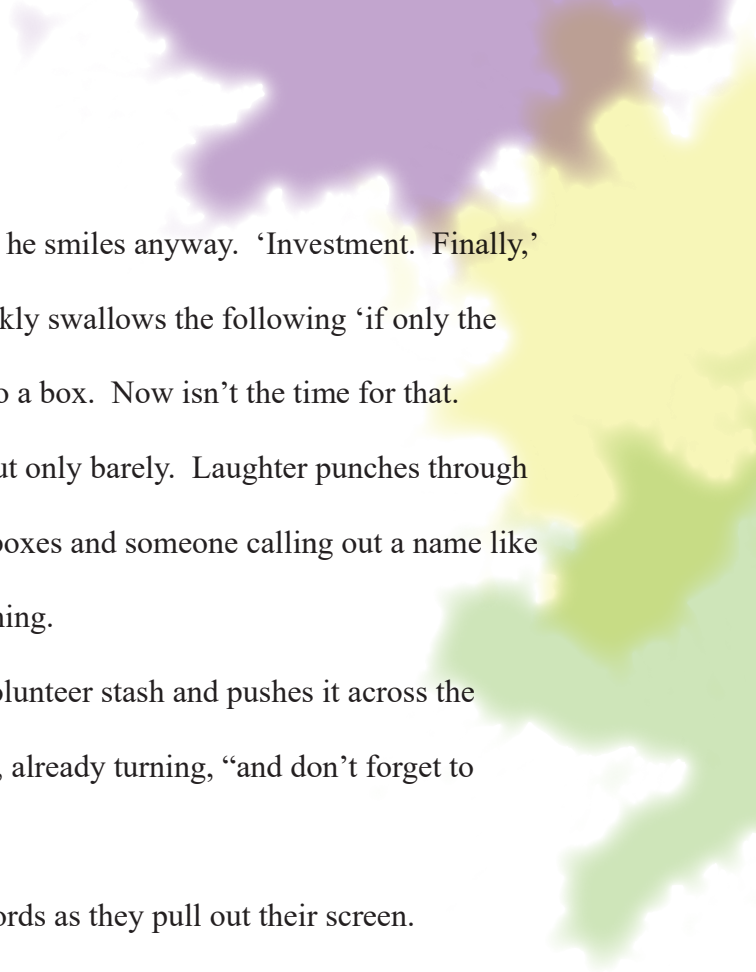
Audrina doesn’t react for a solid three seconds. It’s the first time someone hasn’t either rolled their eyes, caved, or written them off. “Yeah,” they finally respond, a little dumbly, unfurling and glancing away.

Rama grins but immediately wipes it off their face. “Say, you’re an artist, yes? Wanna take a pause and help me make the tags for all the bags?”

Audrina lights up. *Finally*. Something they’re good at. “Yes, yes, yes! What are the specs? Can I use colors? How many do we need?” They are already clapping their hands with excitement.

Rama beams. “You can do anything you want, as long as they have the group name somewhere and a contact number if there is an issue. But if you wanna add movie quotes, motivational lines, or just hearts and butterflies, that’s cool with me.”

Audrina giggles and does a happy dance as they follow Rama to a small side room with all the supplies they need. They are already brimming with ideas and bursting with questions. “Who is going to be getting these? What ages? What background? What-” The professional overtakes the toddler. The labor means nothing in the face of using their screen and infinite collapsible digital tags for physical bags. They never get to play with such interesting things when designing for clients.



Rama sighs internally. So loud. So needy. But he smiles anyway. ‘Investment. Finally,’ they think behind briefly closed eyes. Though she quickly swallows the following ‘if only the people they love were enough for that’ and forces it into a box. Now isn’t the time for that.

The side room is quieter than the main space, but only barely. Laughter punches through the wall every few minutes, followed by the scrape of boxes and someone calling out a name like a question. The whole building breathes like a living thing.

Rama grabs a full glass water bottle from the volunteer stash and pushes it across the table to Audrina. “Call if you need anything,” they say, already turning, “and don’t forget to hydrate.”

Audrina hums happily, barely registering the words as they pull out their screen.

Then Rama’s gone with a smile and a slight head shake. Back into the noise, back to the work, leaving Audrina to theirs.

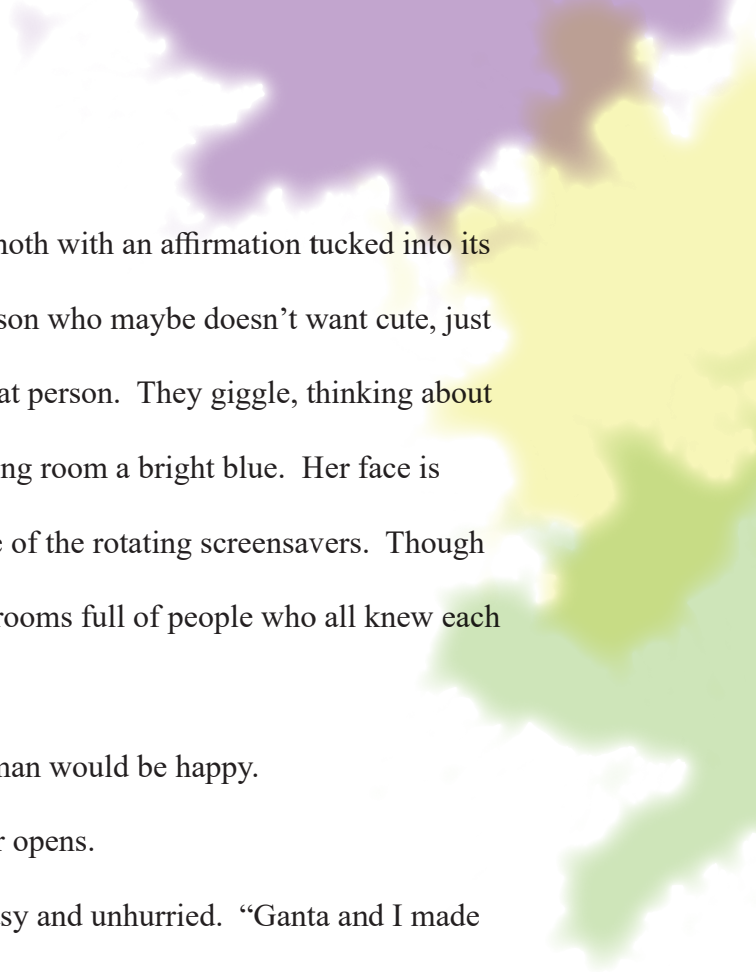
Audrina looks around the table. Tags, blank, and patient. Digital stylus, personal screen, a whole collapsible display waiting for their magic touch.

They relax for the first time all day. No more labor, only colors and swatches.

They swipe up their display, fingers moving before they’ve fully decided anything, and the first tag takes shape almost on its own. A little round creature, part frog, part suggestion of a frog, holding a sign that reads “*You* are doing GREAT, actually!” They tilt their head. Give their froggy a teeny crown. *Perfect.*

The second one is cleaner. Bold type, a border of interlocking leaves. Someone made this for you specifically. ‘Is that too much?’ They think, chewing their lip. ‘No. No, it’s right!’

By the fifth tag, they’ve stopped second-guessing.



Infinity symbols that curve into tiny hearts. A moth with an affirmation tucked into its wings. Something geometric and satisfying for the person who maybe doesn't want cute, just wants to know someone took time. Audrina has met that person. They giggle, thinking about the first time Dice came home to them, painting the living room a bright blue. Her face is immortalized and saved to the apartment display as one of the rotating screensavers. Though Audrina has been that person too, in their own way, in rooms full of people who all knew each other and none of them were looking at them.

They reach for the water without thinking. Duman would be happy.

Before Audrina fully registers the shift, the door opens.

“Lunch time.” Rama leans against the frame, easy and unhurried. “Ganta and I made wraps for everyone.”

Audrina blinks. Looks up. Looks at their display. Looks back at Rama. “But I just started.”

He smiles, chortles at their perplexed face. “It’s been two hours.”

Audrina’s eyes track down Rama’s face, the damp at their temples, the flush across their neck. “Oohhhhh.” They giggle. “That’s why you look sweaty!”

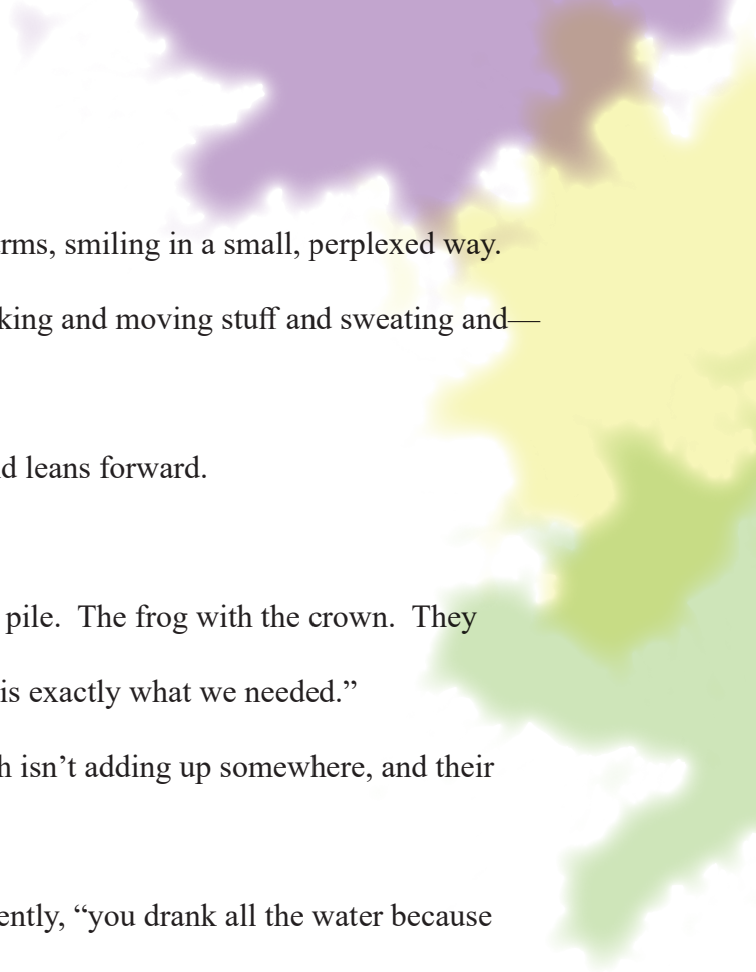
Rama snorts, then lets out a hearty laugh, pulling further giggles from Audrina, who covers their mouth. “Charming.” He shakes his head and leans against the wall beside the door.

“I try! Promise it was a compliment.” Audrina is already standing, stretching their arms above their head with a groan. “You all work so hard.”

“You did too.”

They freeze mid-stretch. “I was just drawing.”

Rama tilts their head. “And contributing.”



“But it was just drawing.” Audrina drops their arms, smiling in a small, perplexed way. His words aren’t landing in their brain. “You were cooking and moving stuff and sweating and— blood, sweat, and tears things, and—”

“Mhmm.” She puts her hands in her pockets and leans forward.

“—and I was just making silly little guys!

Rama picks up the nearest tag from the finished pile. The frog with the crown. They look at it for a moment, then back at Audrina. “Which is exactly what we needed.”

Audrina opens their mouth. Closes it. The math isn’t adding up somewhere, and their face says so plainly.

“And,” Rama adds, setting the tag back down gently, “you drank all the water because you were thinking so hard.”

Audrina looks at the empty bottle.

“Huh.”

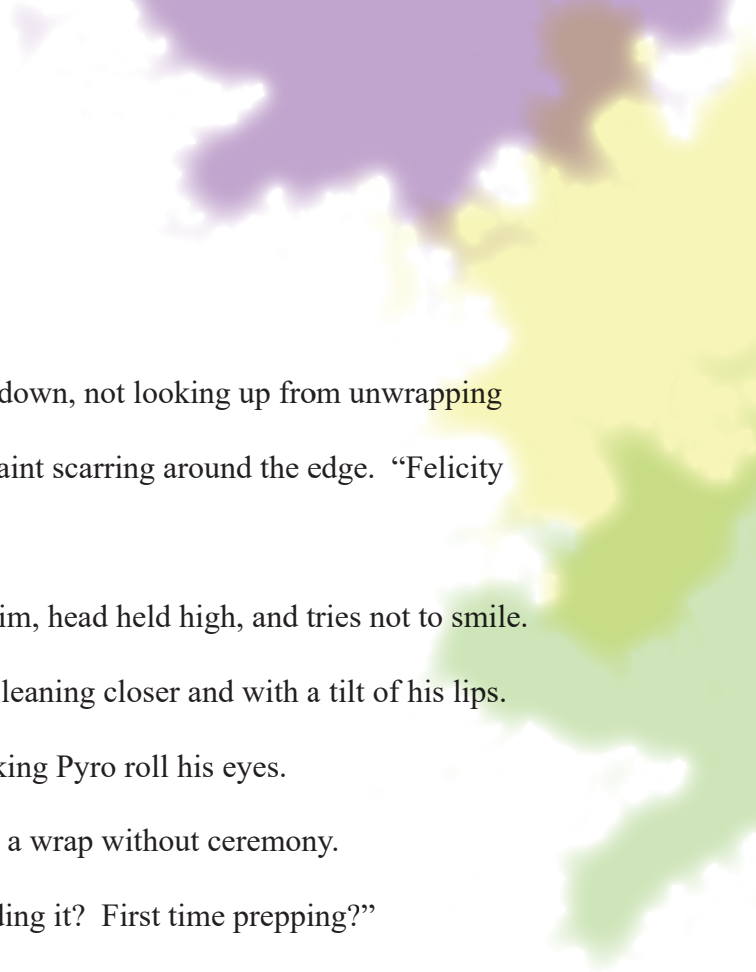
“Come on.” Rama stands and waves for them to follow. “Let’s eat before the vultures start circling.” He laughs, and Audrina can’t help but grin.

The main space has rearranged itself into something like a dining room. Folding tables pushed together, mismatched chairs, wraps in wax paper passed hand to hand down the line. It is loud and warm, smelling of cumin and something sweet Audrina can’t place.

Rama drops into a seat like they’ve done it a thousand times. Audrina sits beside them, a little carefully.

“Tags person!” Felicity announces from across the table, pointing at Audrina with their wrap. “I saw some of them. The frog is going on my wall, just so you know.”

Audrina lights up immediately. “Which one? The crown one.”



“Obviously the crown one.”

“I knew that one was good—”

“We all knew,” says Pyro flatly, from two seats down, not looking up from unwrapping their food. There’s a port visible at their temple, with faint scarring around the edge. “Felicity announced it to the entire main room.”

“I was sharing joy, *Pyro*.” She leans closer to him, head held high, and tries not to smile.

“You were yelling,” he responds dryly, but also leaning closer and with a tilt of his lips.

“Same thing.” She laughs and waves it off, making Pyro roll his eyes.

Audrina is already giggling. Rama passes them a wrap without ceremony.

Ganta leans across the table. “How are you finding it? First time prepping?”

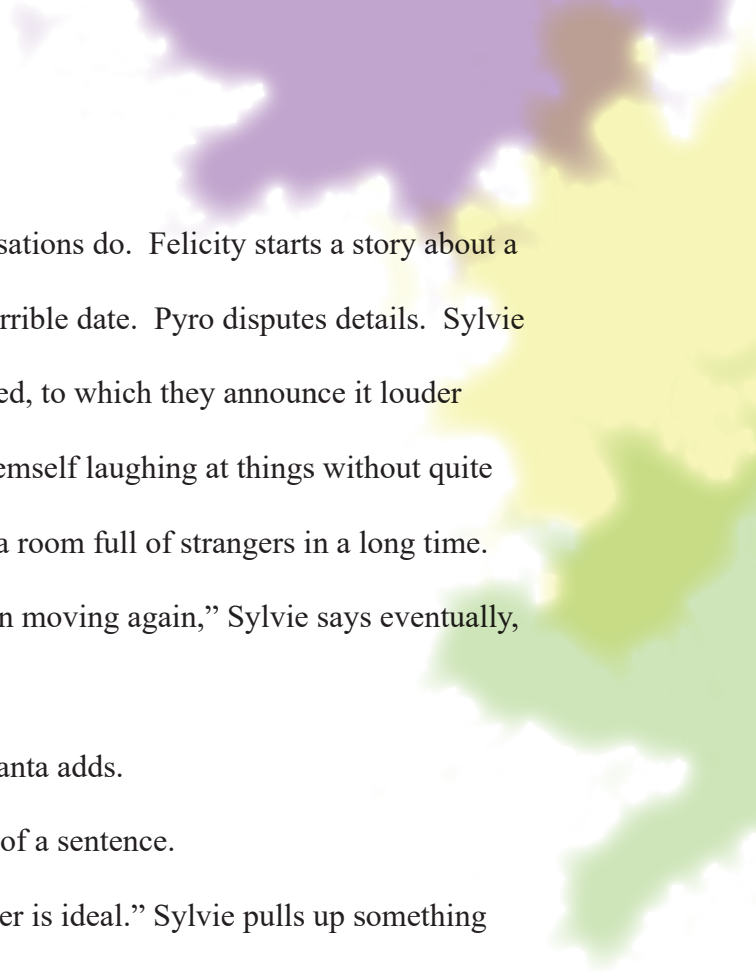
“Is it that obvious?”

“You had *the face*,” Sylvie says from the end of the table, adjusting the knob of their lenses. Audrina didn’t catch when they sat down, and given how rarely you see lenses over eye implants, they definitely should have. “Everyone has *the face* the first time. Like you’ve walked into the wrong building and a goblin might pop out and bite you.” They make a claws out gesture and the worst attempt at a growl. The table giggles or rolls their eyes at Sylvie’s dramatics.

“I did almost leave,” Audrina admits behind their wrap.

“But you didn’t,” Saffi says simply with a half smile. She’s sitting beside Ganta, one arm sleeved in components from the elbow down, eating one-handed with the practiced ease of someone who stopped thinking about it years ago. She doesn’t make it a compliment, just a fact.

Audrina isn’t sure what to do with that, so they take a bite of their wrap.



The conversation scatters the way lunch conversations do. Felicity starts a story about a transit delay that somehow ends with someone else's terrible date. Pyro disputes details. Sylvie fact-checks something on their screen, only to be ignored, to which they announce it louder and get groans, but acknowledgment. Audrina finds herself laughing at things without quite tracking how they got there, which hasn't happened in a room full of strangers in a long time.

"We've been trying to get the community garden moving again," Sylvie says eventually, veering back. "The funding fell through last quarter."

"And the plot we had access to got rezoned," Ganta adds.

"Corporate," Pyro says, like a period at the end of a sentence.

"We're looking at two other locations, but neither is ideal." Sylvie pulls up something on their screen. "Soil testing alone is going to eat most of what we have left in the discretionary fund."

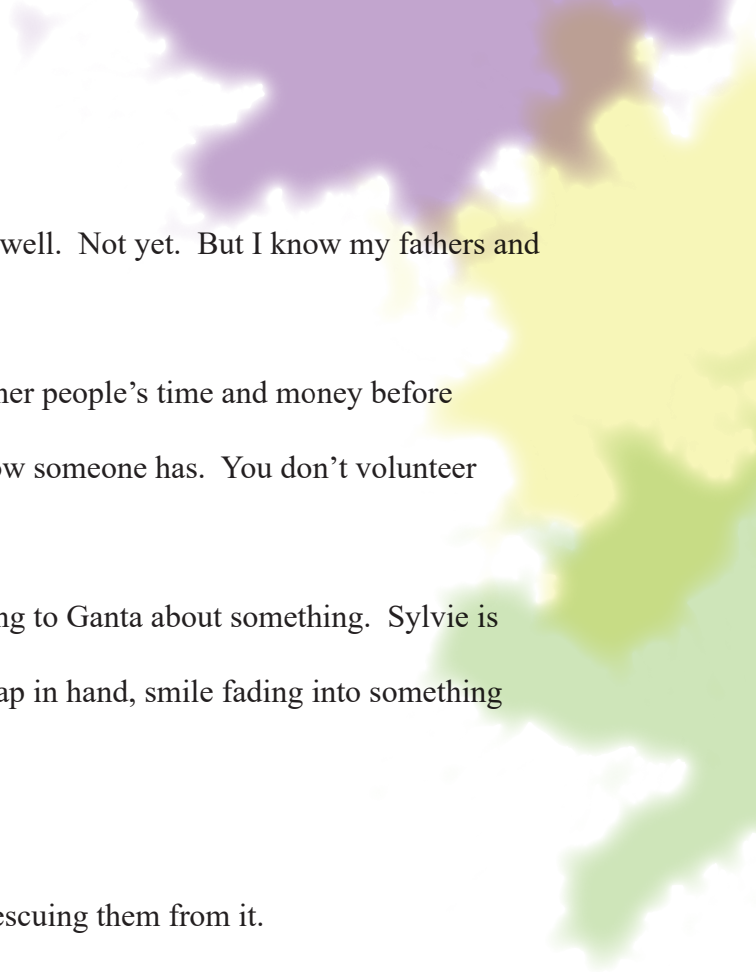
"And that's before tending," Saffi says. "Money is one problem. Consistent bodies showing up is another."

"Harder problem," Rama says quietly, from beside Audrina.

Audrina has been nodding along, genuinely interested, wrap half-eaten. And then the thought arrives fully formed, warm and automatic, the way these thoughts always do.

"Oh! My fathers would probably love to fund the soil testing, that's exactly the kind of thing they—" They're already reaching for their screen. "And my design firm has sustainable build materials just sitting in storage, and Dice attends NekoTech's Science school thing, so she might be able to—"

"Did you ask any of them?" Pyro asks plainly with a near-bored expression.



Audrina's mouth stays open for a second. "I— well. Not yet. But I know my fathers and they would—"

"Sure," Pyro says. "But you're volunteering other people's time and money before you've asked them. Doesn't matter how much you know someone has. You don't volunteer someone else, yeah?"

The table doesn't go quiet. Felicity is still talking to Ganta about something. Sylvie is still on their screen. It's just Audrina sitting with it, wrap in hand, smile fading into something more uncertain.

They glance at Rama.

Rama is eating, completely unhurried and not rescuing them from it.

"Yeah," Audrina says, after an awkward beat. "Ask first. Yeah."

Pyro nods once, done. Already moving on as Felicity drags him into a debate about street lamps.

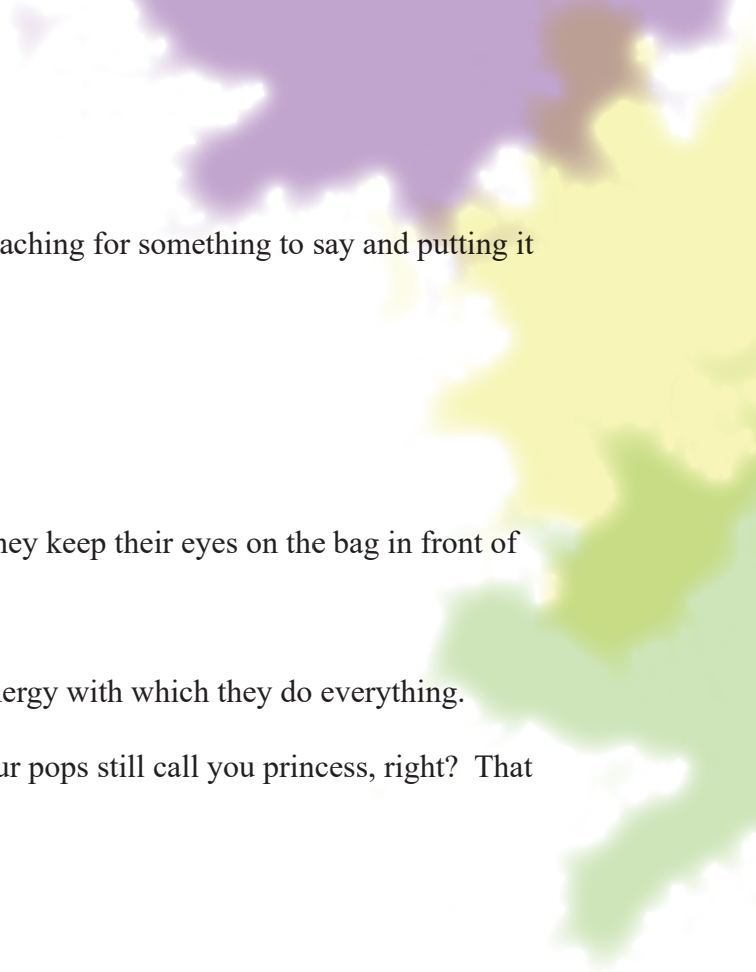
Audrina takes a bite. It really is good. Spicy and flavorful and still warm. The conversation picks back up around them, and they let it, quieter now than they were five minutes ago.

They need to ask Duman about how to make a good burrito.

The afternoon stretches long and quiet.

Someone puts music on in the main space, low enough that it's more texture than sound. Audrina and Rama work through the bag assembly without much ceremony, snack, disposable hologram with resources, sealed, and a tag. Repeat. The rhythm is simple enough that Audrina's hands can do it while the rest of them is somewhere else entirely.

Rama doesn't ask where.



An hour passes, maybe more. Audrina keeps reaching for something to say and putting it back.

Then, finally, they barely murmur, “Babs?”

Rama glances over. “Audi?”

Audrina smiles a little at that. Then it fades. They keep their eyes on the bag in front of them. “Am I... selfish?”

Rama considers this with the same unhurried energy with which they do everything. “Eh.” He reaches for another snack pack. “I mean, your pops still call you princess, right? That tracks.”

“But— like—”

“Audrina.”

“Yeah?”

“You’re imperfect and *growing*.”

Audrina opens their mouth. Closes it. Starts again. “But I’m *still*—”

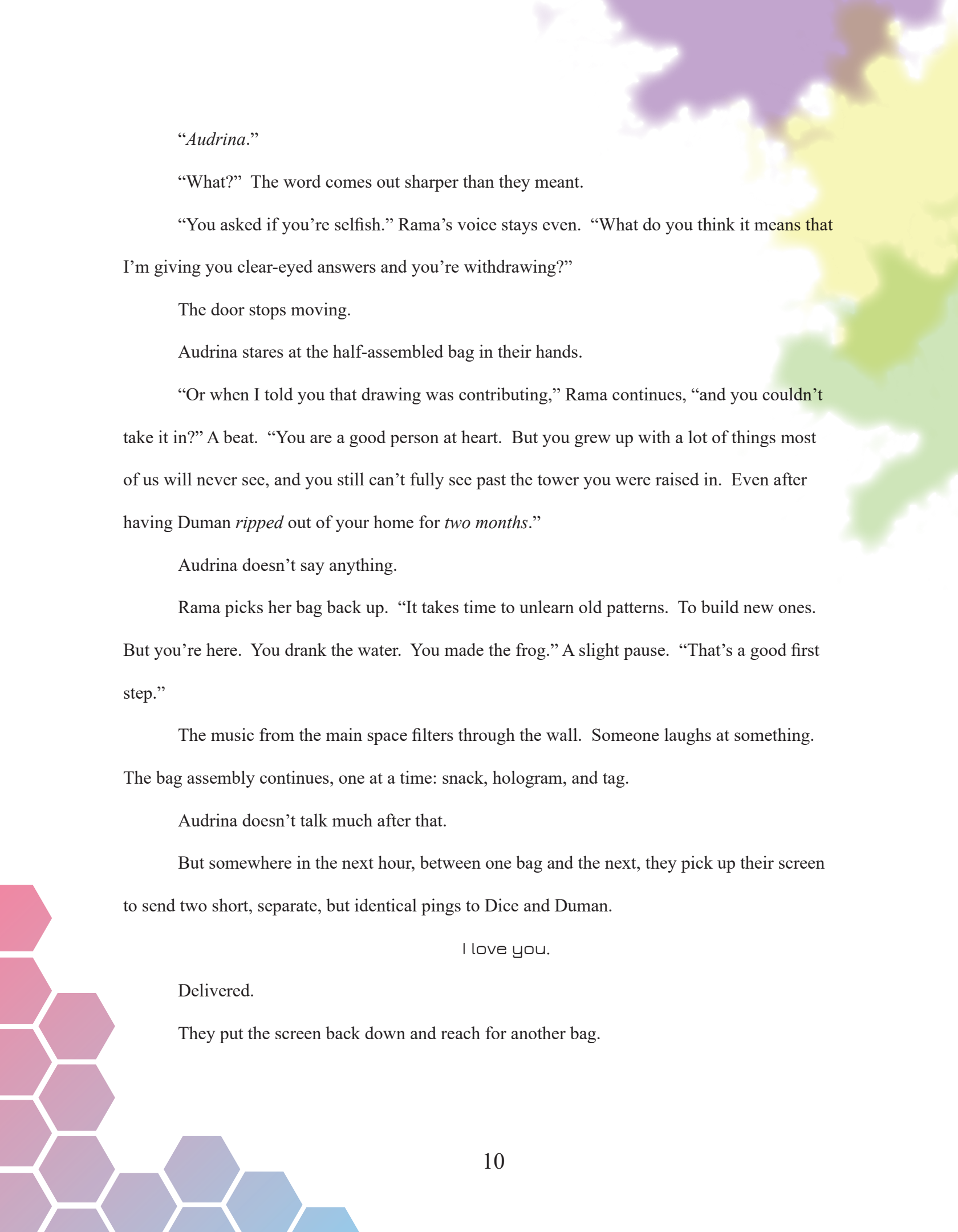
“Entitled, naive, and sheltered.”

It lands quietly. Rama’s voice doesn’t change register, doesn’t sharpen. The boxed thoughts have opened, but nothing is being thrown.

Audrina’s hands slow on the bag.

“Audi.” Rama sets down what she’s holding and turns slightly toward them. “You live with two cyborgs who have been through two very different kinds of hell. And it has taken this long for you to move past doing activism for *you*.”

The silence that follows has a specific texture. Audrina’s shoulders pull in. Their jaw tightens. Something behind their eyes starts to close like a door.



“Audrina.”

“What?” The word comes out sharper than they meant.

“You asked if you’re selfish.” Rama’s voice stays even. “What do you think it means that I’m giving you clear-eyed answers and you’re withdrawing?”

The door stops moving.

Audrina stares at the half-assembled bag in their hands.

“Or when I told you that drawing was contributing,” Rama continues, “and you couldn’t take it in?” A beat. “You are a good person at heart. But you grew up with a lot of things most of us will never see, and you still can’t fully see past the tower you were raised in. Even after having Duman *ripped* out of your home for *two months*.”

Audrina doesn’t say anything.

Rama picks her bag back up. “It takes time to unlearn old patterns. To build new ones. But you’re here. You drank the water. You made the frog.” A slight pause. “That’s a good first step.”

The music from the main space filters through the wall. Someone laughs at something. The bag assembly continues, one at a time: snack, hologram, and tag.

Audrina doesn’t talk much after that.

But somewhere in the next hour, between one bag and the next, they pick up their screen to send two short, separate, but identical pings to Dice and Duman.

I love you.

Delivered.

They put the screen back down and reach for another bag.